was the demand for indentured labour in British colonies after the abolition of slavery in 1834. The initial demand came from sugar cane plantations, but soon Indians were being used to build railway lines and work mines. In the early years, the workers expected to come home at the end of the indenture period, but the British decided that it was cheaper to encourage Indians to settle in the colonies. Thus, Indian women were encouraged to join their menfolk. The indentured workers faced a hard life, but the migration process was given a boost by the Great Famine of 1877. In this way, large Indian communities came to settle in faraway British colonies like Fiji, Trinidad, Guyana, Malaya, South Africa and Mauritius. The French colony of Reunion and the Dutch colony of Surinam also received substantial numbers. The place where half a million Indian workers landed in Mauritius is preserved as 'Aapravasi Ghat' (Immigration Depot) and now is a UNESCO World Heritage Site. [27]

A surviving example of a contract for an indentured worker of that period reads as follows: [28]

> I, Peroo, engage to proceed to Mauritius to serve E. Antard, pere, or such other persons as I may be transferred to (such transfer being made by mutual consent, to be declared before a public officer), as a khidmutgar, for the space of five years from the date of this agreement, on consideration of receiving a remuneration of Company's rupees ten (10) per month, and food and clothing as follows; viz
>
> Daily:
>
> 14 chittanks rice, 2 chittanks dholl, 1/2 chiitanks ghee, 1/4 chittanks salt.
>
> Yearly:
> 1 blanket, 2 dhooties, 1 chintz mirjace, 1 lascar's cap, 1 wooden bowl
> … also one lotah or brass cup between four persons, and medicine and medical attendance when required; also to be sent back to Calcutta at the expiration of my period of service, free of all expense to myself, should such be my wish, subject to the terms of my general agreement. Executed this day ____ of November 1837.

The contract is followed by a short note signed by F.W. Birch, Superintendent of Calcutta Police that describes Peroo as 'Height, 5 feet, 3 inches; age 28 years; colour, light; particular marks, none; caste Mussalman.' Hundreds of thousands of Indians would have left their homes